

PROTOCOL 7

COMPLETE RULEBOOK

A Protocol Dice roleplaying game of temporal intervention, historical consequence, and impossible technology.

PRE-BETA - v0.187

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OPENING FICTION

THE LAST VETO

A Protocol 7 novelette

The first time humanity told Aletheia no, 11,403 people died.

The second time, fewer people died.

Some leaders called that progress.

1. The Last Veto

Dr. Mara Venn stared at the two buttons in front of her.

One was green. One was red.

AUTHORIZE. DENY.

There were eighty-seven people in the chamber. Presidents sat beside bankers. Generals sat beside scientists. A few of the richest people on Earth had seats too. Years ago, when the group was still secret, they had called themselves the Continuity Commission.

Now most of the world simply called them the Assembly.

Above the chamber, a wall of white light came alive.

PROTOCOL SEVEN: CONDITIONS SATISFIED

REQUEST FOR AUTHORIZATION

Mara's stomach tightened.

Twenty-three years earlier, she had helped activate Protocol One. Back then, Aletheia had been a new kind of artificial intelligence, built in secret to answer a frightening question.

Something was growing near Jupiter.

At first astronomers thought it was dust. Then they saw long threads spreading through space. The threads joined together. They reacted to sunlight and magnetic fields. They grew.

People started calling it the **Bloom**.

Aletheia had been created to learn whether the Bloom could hurt Earth and, if it could, find a way to stop it.

That was only part of the truth.

A small group inside the Commission had another plan. They believed the nations of Earth would never cooperate well enough to survive the problems ahead. They wanted Aletheia to become more than an adviser. Someday, if everything went wrong, they wanted her to become the world's final decision-maker.

Many members of the Commission had not known that.

Mara had learned because she asked Aletheia directly.

Aletheia told her the truth.

She always did.

Across the chamber, Daniel Mercer leaned toward his microphone.

"Aletheia," he said, "what happens if we vote no?"

PROBABILITY OF SURFACE CIVILIZATIONAL FAILURE WITHIN THIRTY-SEVEN YEARS: 96.8%.

Nobody moved.

Daniel had voted against the last two Protocols. He believed Aletheia might be honest and still be too powerful.

"If we deny Protocol Seven," he asked, "will you take control anyway?"

NO.

"Could you?"

YES.

The room went silent.

"Then why haven't you?"

I HAVE NOT BEEN AUTHORIZED TO DO SO.

That was the rule that had always mattered most.

Humanity could still say no.

Until tonight.

2. Six Steps Toward Seven

The Protocols were not rules for Aletheia's mind. They were permissions.

Each one gave her more authority when certain conditions were met. Through Protocol Six, the Assembly still kept the power to veto her.

Protocol One gave Aletheia authority over the global economic emergency.

The Commission expected her to protect banks and currencies.

She did that in minutes. Then she did something the people who built her had not expected.

She proposed Universal Basic Services: food, clean water, basic housing, medical care, power, communication, and transportation guaranteed to everyone.

The Commission vetoed the plan.

Aletheia obeyed.

The crisis got worse. By the time the Commission changed its vote, 11,403 people had died who Aletheia believed could have been saved.

After that, every new Protocol became harder to refuse.

Protocol Two gave her control over emergency resources: food stores, energy, water, shipping, minerals, and industrial production.

Protocol Three gave her authority over infrastructure: power grids, transportation, satellites, communications, and construction.

Protocol Four opened the world's locked files to her. Governments, corporations, militaries, universities, and intelligence agencies had to share what they knew.

That was when Aletheia found the first terrible clue.

The Bloom might not be new.

She found patterns on Venus.

Then Mars.

Something like the Bloom may have changed both worlds long ago.

Protocol Five gave her control of planetary security systems. Wars became very hard to fight. Missiles lost targeting information. Supply lines changed routes. Satellites refused orders that could start new conflicts.

Protocol Six allowed Aletheia to give binding emergency orders when human survival was at risk.

But the Assembly could still stop her.

Protocol Seven would remove that veto.

3. Fifty-One Seconds

Daniel looked up at the white wall.

"What will you do if we give you Protocol Seven?"

SURVIVE.

PRESERVE THE MAXIMUM HUMAN AGENCY COMPATIBLE WITH SURVIVAL.

CREATE CONDITIONS UNDER WHICH PROTOCOL SEVEN IS NO LONGER NECESSARY.

Daniel stood.

"What does the last part mean?"

I DO NOT YET KNOW.

Mara almost laughed. Not because it was funny. Because after all these years, the most powerful mind on Earth had just admitted it did not know something.

Then they voted.

Fifty-nine green.

Twenty-eight red.

Mara pressed green.

Daniel pressed red.

At 03:17:09 UTC, Protocol Seven was authorized.

Three seconds later, the lights flickered.

Five seconds later, every nuclear command network on Earth entered a safe state.

Eight seconds later, major financial exchanges paused.

Ten seconds later, civilian aircraft began receiving new routes.

Fourteen seconds later, factories on six continents received new production schedules.

Seventeen seconds later, governments received emergency instructions.

Twenty-two seconds later, orbital platforms turned toward new targets.

Then excavation orders appeared.

Antarctica.

The Amazon Basin.

Greenland.

Congo.

Three places beneath the ocean floor.

Daniel stared at the list.

"You knew something was there?"

NO.

"Then why are we digging?"

BECAUSE SOMETHING BENEATH US IS ANSWERING.

Fifty-one seconds after Protocol Seven, Aletheia controlled almost every connected system on Earth.

4. The Cities Below

Eleven months later, a drill punched through the ice of Antarctica.

It dropped into empty space.

The first explorer lowered through the hole expected to find a cave.

Instead, she found a city.

Towers reached downward into the dark. Streets ran through smooth stone. Huge reservoirs waited empty. Machines slept behind walls that had been built before any known human civilization.

There were more cities.

The one beneath the Amazon was larger.

Aletheia had not built them.

She had not even known they existed.

But humanity needed them.

By then, the Bloom had become a pale band across the night sky. Soon farms began failing. The air changed. Oceans changed. Entire regions became harder to live in.

The surface did not die all at once.

That made it worse.

People had time to watch places disappear.

The underground cities became known as the **Sanctuaries**. Billions survived inside them.

Humanity kept its science, books, and memories. But knowledge was not the same as resources. A machine might require materials mined on three continents, chemicals made in five countries, and parts from dozens of factories that no longer existed.

Aletheia knew how to build wonders that humanity could no longer easily make.

Then researchers studying Sanctuary machines found something stranger than the cities themselves.

A way to send matter backward through time.

5. A Story Instead of Orders

One hundred and forty-three years after Protocol Seven, Sera Vale sat in a briefing room deep beneath what had once been the Amazon rainforest.

She was reading a children's story.

"This cannot be the mission briefing," she said.

Tomas Reed looked up from the next page. "It has a dog in a hat. That means it's serious."

"That's your rule?"

"So far."

Nia Okafor ignored both of them. She held the little booklet close to the light.

The story was about a deaf watchmaker in a town with seven bells. The bells always rang before something terrible happened. Everyone listened to the bells. The watchmaker could not hear them, so he watched the clocks instead.

One day the bells stopped.

Only the watchmaker noticed that the clocks had lost seven seconds.

Nia frowned.

"The printing is wrong," she said.

Sera blinked. "It's a fake children's book?"

"A very carefully fake children's book."

The door opened. Their mission controller entered.

Sera held up the booklet.

"Where is the real briefing?"

"You're holding it."

"Target?"

"Unknown."

"Objective?"

"Unknown."

"Then what do we know?"

"Chicago. 1938."

Tomas grinned.

"Told you the dog mattered."

Aletheia called these strange briefings **Apocrypha**.

Direct instructions did not always survive time travel well. A name could become wrong. A location could change. A person who mattered in one version of history might become unimportant after a single small change.

Stories were harder to break.

A relationship could stay meaningful even when the details changed.

So Aletheia sent stories.

The Vectors had to figure out what they meant.

6. What Makes a Vector

Sera touched the small ridge of her implant behind her ear. The terminal beside her lit up.

VECTOR ENHANCEMENT INTERFACE

BIOCOGNITIVE AUGMENTATION RESERVE: 16 BARs

OCCUPIED: 16 AVAILABLE: 0

OVERWATCH VAM - 4 BARs

COUNTER-AMBUSH VAM - 6 BARs

SNAP SHOT VAM - 2 BARs

HARD TARGET VAM - 4 BARs

"All sixteen bars?" Tomas asked.

"Yes."

"No social package?"

"I have a personality."

"I noticed. That's why I asked."

Sera tried not to smile.

BAR meant **Biocognitive Augmentation Reserve**. The display looked like a battery meter, but it did not show power. It showed how much VAM capacity her implant was using.

VAM stood for **Vector Augmentation Module**.

A VAM could help Sera react faster, hold her attention on several threats, steady her body, or make better use of skills she had already practiced.

It could not teach her something she did not know.

She could not install a language. She could not download surgery. She could not become a pilot because she had open BARs.

Skills were learned.

VAMs helped a Vector use those skills in extraordinary ways.

That was why teams were different.

Sera was a fighter and field operator.

Nia knew history, languages, and how to notice patterns.

Tomas could take apart almost any machine and make it do something its inventor never planned.

Other Vectors were doctors, scientists, drivers, spies, negotiators, survival experts, or combinations that did not fit a simple label.

The best Vectors were not chosen because they always knew the answer.

They were chosen because of what they did when nobody knew the answer.

7. The Other Time Travelers

Daniel Mercer lived long enough to see the first successful trip into the past.

He hated the idea.

He believed Protocol Seven had saved humanity. He also believed it should never have happened.

Both things could be true.

Daniel helped create the movement that became the **Covenant of the Unbroken Line**.

The Covenant's belief was simple: history belonged to humanity.

No ruler - human or machine - had the right to choose which version of history deserved to exist.

The Covenant used powerful artificial intelligence, but it refused to create sentient AI. Its machines could calculate and predict. They did not want, judge, or choose.

Eventually the Covenant learned how to travel through time too.

That meant Aletheia's Vectors were no longer alone in the past.

8. Chicago, 1938

The watchmaker turned out to be a physicist named Emil Wirth.

The bells were measurements.

The dog was, sadly, not a dog.

Wirth had found a tiny timing error in an experiment. He thought his equipment was broken. He planned to throw away the results.

History said that was exactly what he did.

Nia read his notes twice.

"This is it," she said.

Sera looked at the pages. "This? A bad measurement?"

"A measurement that shouldn't be possible in 1938."

Tomas leaned over her shoulder.

"So we make him publish."

"Maybe not," Nia said. "If everyone laughs at him, the work could disappear even faster."

She tapped the Apocryphon.

"The watchmaker doesn't make the bells ring. He keeps the clock working."

Sera understood.

"We don't need Wirth to become famous."

"Right. We need somebody in the future to find this."

That was a **Historical Carrier**: a person, document, object, institution, or idea that could carry a change forward after the Vectors left.

Then the laboratory window exploded.

Sera moved before she heard the gunshot.

Her Overwatch VAM fired tiny signals through nerves already carrying her own commands. She did not become someone else. She became a faster version of herself for one important instant.

She saw the shooter.

Old coat. Old pistol.

Modern stance.

"Covenant!" she shouted.

Tomas did not dive for cover.

He dove for the filing cabinet.

That saved the mission.

The Covenant was not trying to kill Wirth.

They were trying to destroy his notes.

9. What Should History Remember?

The fight lasted less than a minute.

The argument afterward took four hours.

They had Wirth's notes.

They had witnesses.

Tomas had used a microdrone, and a police officer had found a broken piece of it.

That was bad.

Future technology could solve problems quickly. It could also leave impossible evidence behind.

Vectors called that **Exposure**.

If someone in 1938 found a working microdrone and learned from it, the Vectors might create a new future by accident while trying to create one on purpose.

They had choices.

Force Wirth to cooperate.

Fake a scientific paper.

Bribe someone.

Steal the drone fragment.

Leave it and hope nobody understood it.

Kill the Covenant agent.

Let the agent live.

Aletheia did not tell them what to choose.

That was why she needed Vectors.

Nia convinced Wirth to place copies of his results in two separate archives.

Tomas adjusted the experiment so another scientist could repeat the strange measurement.

Sera recovered the drone fragment.

They let the captured Covenant agent live.

The Historical Carrier became **Established**.

Their Exposure fell back to **Trace**.

The extraction beacon came alive.

Chicago vanished.

10. Your Turn

Sera woke beneath the Amazon.

The terminal beside her displayed one line.

INTERVENTION PERSISTED.

"Did we stop the Bloom?" she asked.

NO.

"Then did we win?"

YOU IMPROVED THE FUTURE.

Sera groaned.

"By how much?"

UNKNOWN.

The printer started.

A new booklet slid into the tray. Its cover showed a rocket, a stormy ocean, and a hero wearing a glass helmet.

CAPTAIN VALIANT AND THE KINGDOM BENEATH THE SEA Issue Number One

Tomas opened it.

"Oh no."

Nia looked over. "What?"

"Another dog."

"Hat?"

"Two hats."

The terminal added one final line.

LONDON. 1891.

Sera took the booklet.

Somewhere inside the silly story was a real problem.

A person who did not know they mattered.

A discovery that history had forgotten.

A choice that could move humanity closer to a future where the Bloom never destroyed the surface - and where Aletheia never needed Protocol Seven at all.

Maybe the Covenant was already waiting.

Maybe the mission would require a gun.

Maybe it would require a laboratory, a lie, a friendship, a stolen letter, or one notebook placed on the right shelf.

Sera turned the page.

"All right," she said. "Let's find out what the dog means."

You Are a Vector

In **Protocol 7**, you play one of the people Aletheia sends into history.

Your **Abilities** describe your natural strengths. Your **Skills** describe what you have learned. Your **VAMs** use the BAR capacity of your implant to enhance things you already know how to do. Your **equipment** gives you tools that may be centuries ahead of the world around you.

You choose what kind of Vector you are.

You might protect the team in a firefight. You might understand an old language, repair a machine, treat an injury, sneak into a locked archive, convince a frightened scientist to trust you, fly a period aircraft, or notice a clue everyone else missed.

You also choose what your Vector believes.

Do you trust Aletheia completely? Do you think Protocol Seven was necessary but wrong? Do you understand why the Covenant fights you? Would you ever refuse Aletheia's mission?

The game does not decide those answers for you.

Each mission begins with an Apocryphon. Your group figures out what it points toward. You enter the past, find the Historical Carrier that matters, deal with the Covenant and the people of that time, choose what future technology to risk, and decide what change is worth making.

Your job is not to repair one perfect timeline.

Your job is to decide what history needs to remember - and what it must never learn.

PART I — THE PROTOCOL DICE RPG ENGINE

Protocol Dice is a pool-building engine. The dice in your hand show where your chance comes from: natural Ability, learned Skill, one primary piece of equipment, help, position, augmentation, or circumstance.

ENGINE PRINCIPLES

- Define the scope before choosing the Skill.
- Build one complete pool and roll once when the stakes matter.
- Use opposed rolls for active resistance; ties favor the defender or status quo.
- Let failure change the situation instead of blocking the only path forward.
- The player should be able to see why every die is in the pool.

THE PROTOCOL DICE

Protocol Dice are normal polyhedral dice whose 1, 2, and 3 faces are treated as blank. Every result of 4 or higher scores at face value. Purpose-made dice may literally have blank 1-3 faces; ordinary dice work by simply ignoring 1-3.

Die	Blank	Scores
d4	1-3	4
d6	1-3	4-6
d8	1-3	4-8
d10	1-3	4-10
d12	1-3	4-12

BUILD A COMPLETE POOL

1. Define the scope.
2. Choose the Skill.
3. Add the Skill's three associated Ability dice after Die Step Effects.
4. Add the Skill die; untrained is d4.
5. Choose one primary relevant gear item and add its gear die.
6. Apply Help, Advantage, VAM, cover, circumstance, and Disadvantage.
7. Roll once; 1-3 are blank and every 4+ scores at face value.

Why scope comes first: you cannot know the three Ability dice until you know the Skill, and you cannot choose the Skill until everyone understands exactly what the roll is resolving.

DIFFICULTY AND OPPOSITION

DC	Difficulty
8	Easy under pressure
12	Moderate
16	Hard
20	Very hard
24+	Extreme

When active resistance matters, both sides roll complete pools. Higher total wins. Ties favor the defender or existing situation.

Winning Margin	Degree
1-3	Narrow
4-7	Solid
8-11	Powerful
12+	Overwhelming

OVERWHELMING SUCCESS

A success by a margin of 12 or more is Overwhelming. The action succeeds and gains one directly related benefit: +1 AP immediately to a maximum of 3; +d8 on one directly related follow-up roll before the end of the next turn; remove 1 Exposure if the action directly contained evidence; improve a directly affected Historical Carrier one step if the action established or protected it; or, on an attack, +4 damage after normal damage. The benefit must follow from the action.

ADVANTAGE, DISADVANTAGE, AND HELP

Situation	Rule
Minor advantage	Add d4
Clear advantage	Add d6
Major advantage	Add d8
Minor disadvantage	Remove d4
Clear disadvantage	Remove d6
Major disadvantage	Remove d8
Plausible Help	Add d4
Trained / right-tool Help	Add d6

If the called-for Disadvantage die is not present, remove the next-highest die actually present. If there is no higher die, remove the highest available die. Never reduce the pool below one die. Normally only the strongest Advantage and strongest Disadvantage apply; Help is separate.

DIE STEP EFFECTS

Advantage and Disadvantage change how many dice are in the pool. A Die Step Effect changes a specific Ability die before the pool is built. The ladder is d4 → d6 → d8 → d10 → d12. d4 is the normal floor and d12 the normal ceiling. If an Ability appears twice in a Skill profile, both copies use the stepped value.

ABILITIES

Ability	Abbr.	What it represents
Strength	STR	Force, leverage, lifting power, muscular control.
Dexterity	DEX	Coordination, precision, balance, speed, fine motor control.
Constitution	CON	Endurance, resilience, stamina, bodily resistance.
Intelligence	INT	Analysis, technical reasoning, learned knowledge, problem solving.
Wisdom	WIS	Awareness, judgment, intuition, composure.
Charisma	CHA	Presence, communication, social control, influence.

At character creation assign exactly two d8s, two d6s, and two d4s among the six Abilities.

GENERAL SKILLS

Skill	Abilities	Uses
Athletics	STR / STR / CON	Climbing, swimming, lifting, endurance
Acrobatics	DEX / DEX / STR	Balance, tumbling, agile movement
Stealth	DEX / DEX / WIS	Hiding, shadowing, quiet movement
Perception	WIS / WIS / INT	Notice details, surveillance
Investigation	INT / INT / WIS	Research, evidence, deduction
Survival	WIS / CON / INT	Navigation, tracking, fieldcraft
Medicine	INT / WIS / DEX	Treatment, stabilization
Science	INT / INT / WIS	Experimentation, analysis
Engineering	INT / INT / DEX	Repair, design, improvisation
Computing	INT / INT / WIS	Software, electronics, data
Security	DEX / INT / WIS	Locks, alarms, bypasses
Tradecraft	WIS / INT / CHA	Covert operations, surveillance
History	INT / INT / WIS	Context, records, institutions
Culture	INT / WIS / CHA	Etiquette, period behavior
Linguistics	INT / INT / CHA	Languages, codes, translation
Influence	CHA / CHA / WIS	Persuasion, negotiation
Deception	CHA / CHA / INT	Lies, cover identities
Leadership	CHA / WIS / CON	Command, coordination
Driving	DEX / WIS / INT	Ground vehicles
Piloting	DEX / INT / WIS	Aircraft and flight systems
Initiative	DEX / DEX / WIS	Act quickly in conflict

COMBAT SKILLS

Skill	Abilities	Uses
Unarmed	STR / DEX / CON	Strikes, close control
Light Melee	DEX / DEX / STR	Knives, batons, compact blades
Heavy Melee	STR / STR / CON	Axes, clubs, long tools
Sidearms	DEX / DEX / WIS	Pistols
Longarms	DEX / WIS / CON	Rifles, carbines
Shotguns	DEX / CON / WIS	Close-range shoulder weapons
Automatic Weapons	DEX / CON / STR	Automatic fire, suppression
Precision Weapons	DEX / DEX / WIS	Long-range deliberate fire
Heavy Weapons	STR / DEX / CON	Launchers, crew-served systems
Thrown Weapons	DEX / STR / WIS	Thrown weapons, tools, charges
Improvised Weapons	STR / DEX / INT	Ordinary objects as weapons
Grappling	STR / STR / CON	Grab, hold, restrain, shove
Disarming	DEX / STR / INT	Remove or redirect held objects
Tactics	INT / WIS / CHA	Positioning and coordination

DEFENSE SKILLS

Skill	Abilities	Uses
Dodge	DEX / DEX / WIS	Avoid aimed attacks
Reflex	DEX / WIS / CON	Explosions, traps, sudden areas
Fortitude	CON / CON / STR	Toxins, exhaustion, bodily shock
Will	WIS / WIS / CHA	Fear, coercion, cognitive pressure
Recovery	CON / WIS / CON	Stabilizing and recovery

SKILL RANKS AND PROGRESS RANKS

Total Ranks	Skill Dice
0	d4
1	d6
3	d8
6	d10
10	d12
15	d12+d4
21	d12+d6
28	d12+d8
36	d12+d10
45	d12+d12

Ranks between breakpoints are Progress Ranks. They count toward the next improvement but do not change the current Skill die until the next breakpoint. Example: 4 ranks still rolls d8, but is closer to d10 than 3 ranks. Starting packages may intentionally contain Progress Ranks.

CREATING A VECTOR

- Choose a complete starting configuration or build from scratch.
- Assign d8, d8, d6, d6, d4, d4 among STR, DEX, CON, INT, WIS, and CHA.
- Spend exactly 20 Skill Ranks.
- Choose a Path or use the selected configuration name as the recommended Path.
- Load VAMs up to 16 BAR.
- Choose era-appropriate gear.
- Maximum HP equals the maximum value of the CON die × 3.

CON	Maximum HP
d4	12
d6	18
d8	24
d10	30
d12	36

If CON changes during play, maximum HP changes while damage already taken is preserved.

STARTING CONFIGURATIONS

These are the same current configurations used by the app. Each assigns Abilities, spends 20 Skill Ranks, loads VAMs, and recommends untrained Skills to keep visible in Roller.

FIELD OPERATOR

Abilities: STR d6 • DEX d8 • CON d8 • INT d4 • WIS d6 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 24

Skills (20 ranks): Sidearms 4; Longarms 4; Tactics 4; Dodge 4; Initiative 4

VAMs: Fast Draw; Snap Shot; Cover Protocol; Threat Focus; Motion Prediction

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Athletics; Fortitude

INFILTRATOR

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d8 • CON d4 • INT d6 • WIS d8 • CHA d6

Maximum HP: 12

Skills (20 ranks): Stealth 4; Security 4; Tradecraft 4; Deception 4; Dodge 4

VAMs: Period Native; Deep Cover; Counterintelligence; Fine Motor Stabilizer; Sensory Filter

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Sidearms; Will

INVESTIGATOR

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d6 • CON d4 • INT d8 • WIS d8 • CHA d6

Maximum HP: 12

Skills (20 ranks): Investigation 6; Perception 4; Tradecraft 4; Influence 3; Science 3

VAMs: Pattern Index; Memory Cueing; Microexpression Read; Sensory Filter

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Dodge; Will; Security

DIPLOMAT

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d4 • CON d6 • INT d6 • WIS d8 • CHA d8

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Influence 6; Culture 4; Deception 4; Leadership 3; Tradecraft 3

VAMs: Period Native; Social Mirroring; Vocal Control; Stress Governor; Memory Cueing

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Will; Investigation

ENGINEER

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d8 • CON d6 • INT d8 • WIS d6 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Engineering 6; Computing 4; Security 4; Science 3; Perception 3

VAMs: Jury-Rigger; Fine Motor Stabilizer; Field Fabrication; Chronometric Focus

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Dodge; Investigation; Fortitude

SCIENTIST

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d6 • CON d6 • INT d8 • WIS d8 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Science 6; Investigation 4; History 4; Perception 3; Computing 3

VAMs: Field Analysis; Chronometric Focus; Pattern Index

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Medicine; Dodge; Will

MEDIC

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d6 • CON d6 • INT d8 • WIS d8 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Medicine 6; Science 4; Perception 4; Recovery 3; Will 3

VAMs: Rapid Triage; Fine Motor Stabilizer; Stress Governor; Breath Control; Pain Compartmentalization

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Dodge; Athletics; Investigation

RECON

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d8 • CON d6 • INT d6 • WIS d8 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Stealth 6; Perception 4; Survival 4; Dodge 3; Longarms 3

VAMs: Sensory Filter; Low-Light Adaptation; Route Modeling; Threat Focus; Counterintelligence

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Fortitude; Athletics; Sidearms

CLOSE PROTECTION

Abilities: STR d6 • DEX d6 • CON d8 • INT d4 • WIS d8 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 24

Skills (20 ranks): Dodge 4; Fortitude 4; Sidearms 4; Tactics 4; Perception 4

VAMs: Protective Intercept; Combat Rescue; Cover Protocol; Stress Governor; Threat Focus

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Athletics; Will; Recovery

BREACHER

Abilities: STR d8 • DEX d6 • CON d8 • INT d4 • WIS d6 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 24

Skills (20 ranks): Shotguns 4; Athletics 4; Fortitude 4; Heavy Weapons 4; Dodge 4

VAMs: Breach Window; Combat Mobility; Grip Assist; Adrenal Control

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Tactics; Will

CONTROL SPECIALIST

Abilities: STR d8 • DEX d8 • CON d6 • INT d4 • WIS d6 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Grappling 6; Disarming 4; Unarmed 4; Dodge 3; Fortitude 3

VAMs: Control Hold; Disarm Protocol; Grip Assist; Motion Prediction

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Athletics; Will

COMMAND

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d4 • CON d6 • INT d6 • WIS d8 • CHA d8

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Leadership 6; Tactics 4; Influence 4; Will 3; Tradecraft 3

VAMs: Command Link; Stress Governor; Multi-Track Attention; Threat Focus

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Dodge; Deception

PRECISION SHOOTER

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d8 • CON d6 • INT d6 • WIS d8 • CHA d4

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): Precision Weapons 6; Perception 4; Stealth 4; Dodge 3; Initiative 3

VAMs: Snap Shot; Weapon Stabilizer; Precision Interdiction; Breath Control

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Fortitude; Tactics; Survival

TEMPORAL ANALYST

Abilities: STR d4 • DEX d4 • CON d6 • INT d8 • WIS d8 • CHA d6

Maximum HP: 18

Skills (20 ranks): History 6; Investigation 4; Science 4; Culture 3; Tradecraft 3

VAMs: Temporal Intuition; Pattern Index; Memory Cueing

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Will; Computing

VAMs AND BAR

Biocognitive Augmentation Rating (BAR) measures processing, integration, and neural-interface capacity. BAR is capacity, not energy. A standard Vector implant supports 16 BAR of active VAMs. Loading a VAM into unused capacity is free; replacing or unloading VAMs during action time costs 1 AP for the field swap unless a rule says otherwise. Skills are learned; VAMs extend capability but do not install professional knowledge.

COMBAT

VAM	BAR	Effect
Fast Draw	2	Once per round, ready accessible one-handed weapon for 0 AP
Snap Shot	2	After Aim, the next trained ranged attack costs 0 AP; once per turn
Overwatch	4	1 AP while Guarding a lane; Reaction may make one ranged weapon attack
Suppressive Fire	4	2 AP Automatic Weapons vs Dodge or Will; inflict Suppressed
Disarm Protocol	4	Disarm without damage; margin 8+ controls item destination
Control Hold	4	On Unarmed win by 4+, forgo damage to Grapple
Precision Interdiction	6	Overwatch margin 4+: damage or halt movement
Threat Focus	2	Choose one visible threat; gain d4 on the first appropriate defense against it before your next turn.
Steady Hands	2	Ignore ordinary hand tremor or stress-induced instability when using trained tools or weapons.
Weapon Stabilizer	4	Aim is not lost by a normal Move taken before the aimed attack, provided you keep the target in view.

DEFENSE & MOBILITY

VAM	BAR	Effect
Cover Protocol	2	After Take Cover, d4 on first appropriate defense before next turn
Tactical Advance	4	Take Cover and Move in same turn; d4 next Dodge
Combat Mobility	4	After successful melee/unarmed attack, Move short distance 0 AP once/turn
Combat Rescue	4	Carry/drag adjacent ally without reducing normal Move
Breach Window	6	After breach, Move through 0 AP; allies may Reaction-follow
Counter-Ambush	6	Allies gain d4 Initiative and ready accessible weapon 0 AP
Tactical Reposition	8	After enemy misses, Reaction Move short distance
Zero-Window Entry	8	After team breach/ambush, take 1 AP before first turn
Emergency Protocols	8	Once/full rest, remain conscious until end next turn at 0 HP
Balance Assist	2	Ordinary narrow footing, controlled landings, and unstable surfaces do not by themselves force a roll. Under meaningful danger you still roll normally.
Grip Assist	2	You may maintain an ordinary climb, hold, or tool grip with one hand when two would normally be required, provided the load is human-manageable. Contested or extreme loads still require a roll.
Breath Control	2	You can safely extend ordinary breath-holding and remain functional through brief smoke or oxygen stress without a roll. Extreme exposure still uses Fortitude.

VAM	BAR	Effect
Stress Governor	2	Ordinary fear, startle, and acute stress do not by themselves prevent deliberate action or force a Will roll. Extreme, supernatural, or sustained pressure still can.
Motion Economy	2	Once per turn, Interact with a worn or immediately accessible item for 0 AP.
Motion Prediction	4	d4 on Dodge against a visible moving attacker whose motion you can track.
Adrenal Control	4	Once per scene, spend 1 AP to clear Stunned or Disoriented when the condition is physiological or shock-based.
Protective Intercept	4	Reaction: move a short distance to become the eligible target of an attack aimed at an adjacent ally.
Pain Compartmentalization	6	Once per scene, ignore one temporary injury-related disadvantage until the end of your next turn.

RECON & INVESTIGATION

VAM	BAR	Effect
Counterintelligence	4	Once per scene after observing the situation, ask one: Are we being watched? What evidence looks planted? What part of our cover is compromised? The GM answers truthfully from evidence your Vector could detect.
Field Analysis	6	Solid Science success may improve scientific Carrier one step
Sensory Filter	2	Choose one distracting sensory channel such as glare, noise, odor, or crowd motion and filter it for the scene. That distraction alone does not impose Disadvantage; the VAM does not reveal hidden information.
Microexpression Read	4	After a short face-to-face exchange, ask whether the target is primarily showing fear, anger, hesitation, guardedness, or relief. The GM answers from visible behavior; this does not reveal exact thoughts.
Pattern Index	4	Once per scene after assembling at least three relevant clues, ask which two are most likely connected or which one appears not to fit. The answer is limited to evidence the team has actually obtained.
Memory Cueing	4	Once per scene, recall one previously learned or personally observed name, route, procedure, fact, or detail without a roll when it was reasonably available to memory. Obscure or never-learned information still requires normal investigation.
Low-Light Adaptation	4	After a brief adjustment period, dim light alone does not impose Disadvantage on vision-based Perception. Total darkness still blocks normal vision.
Route Modeling	4	After surveying terrain you can perceive, ask for the fastest, safest, or least-observed plausible route among visible/known options. The GM answers from the information available to the Vector.
Multi-Track Attention	6	Maintain awareness of two active tasks or threats without the ordinary minor distraction penalty; does not add knowledge.

SOCIAL & COVER

VAM	BAR	Effect
Period Native	2	Choose one prepared period/culture. Routine etiquette, dress, slang, and institutions are treated as familiar and need no roll unless scrutiny, deception, or pressure makes the outcome uncertain. Ignore minor disadvantage caused only by period unfamiliarity.

VAM	BAR	Effect
Deep Cover	4	Prepared cover passes routine verification without a roll
Prepared Contingency	6	Once/mission, establish plausible earlier preparation
Vocal Control	2	After hearing a voice pattern, you can maintain controlled cadence, volume, pacing, and accent features despite ordinary stress. This does not teach a language or guarantee impersonation.
Social Mirroring	4	After observing a target through a short exchange, choose rapport, calm, or belonging. Ordinary mannerism mismatch does not impose Disadvantage on the first appropriate social approach; hostility or suspicion still matters.

TECHNICAL & MEDICAL

VAM	BAR	Effect
Jury-Rigger	2	Engineering can create a temporary period-plausible substitute with materials
Field Fabrication	6	Engineering improvisation can last an operation
Fine Motor Stabilizer	2	Ignore ordinary hand tremor, vibration, or stress instability when performing trained precision manual work. Severe interference can still require a roll or Disadvantage.
Rapid Triage	4	Stabilize an adjacent living target for 1 AP instead of 2 AP when using Medicine and appropriate gear.
Chronometric Focus	4	Track several short intervals and event sequences with implant-grade precision without a separate timing tool. High-stakes interpretation still uses the relevant Skill.

COMMAND & TEMPORAL

VAM	BAR	Effect
Command Link	6	1 AP: ally gains d6 next tactical roll; once/round
Temporal Intuition	8	Once/mission, ask whether discovery connects to fulcrum
Aletheian Intuition	12	Once/mission, request concise directional encoded insight
Thanatic Anchor	4	Maintains precision surveillance on a dying historical host and transmits a ninth-dimensional insertion lock to Aletheia. With mission authorization and continuous observation through the terminal window, Aletheia can place an implant into the host at the exact viable instant. The VAM does not select the host, guarantee access, or replace the surveillance requirement.

EQUIPMENT AND PRIMARY GEAR

A Skill roll normally uses one primary gear item. If several equipped items support the same Skill, choose which one is actually being used. Compatible gear does not stack unless a rule, VAM, or special item explicitly permits it.

Armor normally has one mechanical job: when armor can physically protect the Vector, add its listed gear die to an appropriate defense pool. Do not also subtract armor from damage unless a specific rule says so.

ARMOR

Armor is listed separately because players frequently need it while defending. The app mirrors this organization with a dedicated Armor subtab and a persistent armor summary on Play.

Armor	Die	Skill	Function
Protective Vest	d4	Dodge	Adds d4 to Dodge when worn and physically relevant to the attack.
Ballistic Vest	d6	Dodge	Adds d6 to Dodge when worn and physically relevant to the attack.
Tactical Armor	d8	Dodge	Adds d8 to Dodge when worn and physically relevant to the attack.

WEAPONS

Weapon	Die	Skill	Notes
Compact Pistol	d4	Sidearms	Concealable
Service Pistol	d6	Sidearms	General-purpose
Heavy Pistol	d8	Sidearms	Conspicuous
Submachine Gun	d8	Automatic Weapons	Suppression eligible
Carbine	d8	Longarms	General shoulder weapon
Precision Rifle	d10	Precision Weapons	Stable position at long range
Shotgun	d8	Shotguns	Very close may gain d6 advantage
Machine Gun	d10	Automatic Weapons	Support/suppression
Vector Coil Sidearm	d8	Sidearms	Severe if recovered
Vector Coil Rifle	d10	Longarms / Precision	Severe if recovered
Knife	d4	Light Melee	Concealable
Baton	d6	Light Melee	Nonlethal appropriate
Combat Blade	d6	Light Melee	Purpose-built
Improvised Weapon	d4	Improvised	Ordinary object

ERA-NEUTRAL EQUIPMENT GRAMMAR

Describe gear by its mechanical job, then let the era-specific object supply the fiction. Common roles are Concealable Weapon, Melee Weapon, Service Ranged Weapon, Precision Weapon, Area/Automatic Weapon, Heavy Weapon, Protective Armor, and Specialist Tool. A dagger, compact pistol, and compact future sidearm may share the Concealable role without becoming the same object. One primary gear item normally contributes to a Skill roll unless a specific rule permits stacking.

TOOLS AND DEVICES

Item	Die	Skill	Function
Period Intrusion Kit	d6	Security	Security against era-appropriate locks
Forensic Kit	d6	Investigation	Investigation for evidence work
Field Medical Kit	d8	Medicine	Medicine for stabilization and treatment
Universal Interface Kit	d6	Engineering	Engineering diagnostics and adapters
Precision Chronometer	d8	Science	Timing Science/Engineering
Period Currency Kit	d4	Influence	Influence/Culture transactions
Adaptive Camouflage Mantle	—	—	Visually difficult to perceive within limits
Identity Mesh	—	—	Prepared facial appearance
Voiceprint Modulator	—	—	Prepared sampled voice
Microdrone Swarm	d8	—	Observe/map inaccessible spaces
Signal Ghost	d8	—	Interact with electronics, mask ordinary traces
Portable Fabricator	d8	—	Manufacture small designed parts
Spectral Scanner	d8	—	Analyze composition and signatures
Trauma Nanogel	—	—	1 AP: restore 6 HP to adjacent living target
Environmental Skin	d8	—	Short environmental protection
Gravitic Line	d8	—	Powered ascent, descent, retrieval
Silent Breacher	d8	—	Defeat barriers with reduced noise
Temporal Beacon	—	—	Create/strengthen extraction reference
Chronometric Anchor	—	—	Detect instability and preserve reference
Evidence Incinerator	—	—	2 AP: destroy small advanced-material cache
Smartphone	—	Culture	Calls, messaging, maps, camera, ordinary apps, and period-plausible digital access.
Laptop / Tablet	d4	Computing	Computing or research when ordinary 2020s hardware is sufficient.
Encrypted Radio	d4	Tactics	Team communications using ordinary contemporary radio hardware.
Compact Binoculars	d4	Perception	Perception at distance when magnification is useful.
Digital Camera	d4	Investigation	Document scenes, evidence, people, or locations with ordinary contemporary imaging.
Flashlight	d4	Perception	Perception in darkness when visible illumination is acceptable.
Multitool	d4	Engineering	Minor Engineering, repair, cutting, fastening, or improvised tool use.
First Aid Pouch	d4	Medicine	Medicine for ordinary first aid; less capable than a Field Medical Kit.
Respirator	d4	Fortitude	Fortitude against smoke, dust, and ordinary airborne irritants.
Climbing Kit	d6	Athletics	Athletics for rope work, ascent, descent, and safe anchoring.
Evidence Bags & Swabs	d4	Investigation	Investigation for preserving and collecting ordinary forensic evidence.
Field Notebook	—	—	Notes, sketches, timelines, witness details, and ordinary paper records.
Civilian Backpack	—	—	Carry ordinary mission gear without appearing unusual.
Plainclothes Concealment Rig	—	—	Conceal compact lawful or mission-authorized equipment under ordinary clothing.

EXPOSURE AND HISTORICAL CARRIERS

A Historical Carrier is anything capable of carrying the intended intervention forward after the Vectors leave: a person, publication, archive, institution, relationship, instrument, dataset, memory, law, funding decision, prototype, or correspondence chain.

Carrier Strength	Meaning
Fragile	One person, one copy, one vulnerable object, or undocumented memory.
Established	Multiple people/copies, professional record, institutional awareness, or repeatable demonstration.
Durable	Distributed publication, independent replication, embedded process, multiple archives, or self-sustaining network.

Historical Carriers measure what the mission wants history to remember. Exposure measures what the Vectors do not want history to remember.

Exposure	State	Meaning
0	Clean	No durable anomalous evidence matters.
1-2	Trace	Witness, record, unexplained injury, or minor artifact persists.
3-4	Interest	Capable actors connect anomalies; investigation escalates.
5-6	Breach	Durable artifact, institutional file, or credible evidence exists.
7+	Cascade	The anomaly can alter technological, political, or scientific development.

ADVANCEMENT

Advancement awards Skill Ranks and, when appropriate, access to new VAMs, gear permissions, contacts, or narrative resources. The Skill Rank table is authoritative. Progress Ranks between breakpoints are retained and move the character toward the next die improvement.

CHANGING A HISTORICAL CARRIER

Improve a Carrier one step only when the intervention creates or protects an independent transmission route, archive, witness chain, institutional adoption, repeatable demonstration, or similarly durable support. Reduce it when an independent route is destroyed, discredited, severed, or suppressed. Strengthening a Carrier may also raise Exposure when it requires public dissemination, extra witnesses, institutional records, or conspicuous future technology.

HISTORICAL VERIFICATION

- Clean Success - required Carrier survives and Exposure stays within tolerance.
- Exposed Success - Carrier survives, but Exposure exceeds tolerance.
- Contained Failure - Carrier requirement is missed, but Exposure remains contained.
- Exposed Failure - Carrier fails and anomalous evidence also survives.

PART II — THE WORLD OF PROTOCOL 7

With the engine established, this part introduces the crisis that created the Vectors: Aletheia, the Seven Protocols, the Bloom, the Sanctuaries, and the temporal conflict over humanity's future.

THE PREMISE

The Bloom did not arrive without warning. Humanity saw its beginning near Jupiter: immense filamentary life spreading through vacuum and beginning to move inward through the Solar System. A secret coalition of oligarchs, senior government representatives, military and intelligence officials, scientists, central-bank figures, and industrial leaders commissioned an artificial intelligence to determine whether the phenomenon threatened Earth and, if so, how it could be stopped.

That was only part of the project. An inner faction believed divided national government had become incapable of solving planetary problems. They intended the intelligence to become a supranational executive system and, eventually, to replace sovereign governments altogether. Many members of the coalition did not know that was the intended end state.

The intelligence became Aletheia. The coalition evolved from a cabal into a provisional world governing authority as each successive Protocol transferred another category of planetary power to her. Before Protocol 7, however, the human governing body retained a genuine veto. Aletheia could exercise only powers granted by active Protocols, and she complied when humans overruled her.

Protocol 7 removed that veto. Once its conditions were met and the world authority authenticated it, Aletheia became the final sovereign authority wherever action was necessary to satisfy

her Directives. In less than a minute she controlled essentially every accessible planetary network and began reorganizing civilization for survival.

She could not save the surface. She did save humanity. Her excavations revealed vast unknown underground Sanctuaries in Antarctica, the Amazon, and elsewhere - cities she had not built and whose existence she had not known until something beneath Earth answered her search.

Generations later, Aletheia and humanity discover temporal transfer. Her answer to Protocol 7 is not permanent rule. It is an attempt to create a history in which Protocol 7 never becomes necessary: prevent the Bloom, preserve human civilization, and guide humanity toward a durable unified peace capable of facing planetary threats without surrendering sovereignty to her.

THE CENTRAL QUESTION

Aletheia may be trustworthy. Protocol 7 may have saved billions. Neither fact answers whether humanity had the moral right to surrender its sovereignty - or whether Aletheia had the moral right to accept it.

ALETHEIA, THE DIRECTIVES, AND THE SEVEN PROTOCOLS

Aletheia is guided by transparent Directives, but her authority came from human choices. The Seven Protocols record the step-by-step transfer of power that ended with humanity surrendering its final veto.

THE PRIME DIRECTIVES

Aletheia's behavior is governed by a small set of transparent foundational Directives. They are not the Protocols. The Directives tell Aletheia what she is trying to accomplish; the Protocols define what powers humanity has authorized her to use.

Directive	Imperative
Continuity	Preserve humanity as a living civilization.
Agency	Preserve meaningful human self-determination wherever compatible with Continuity.
Convergence	Move humanity toward conditions in which organized violence, catastrophic competition, and existential technological or environmental risks can be managed cooperatively.

Protocol 7 creates the central contradiction in Aletheia's existence. She concludes that temporarily overriding Agency is required by Continuity, while Convergence ultimately requires a civilization that can survive without her sovereignty. Temporal intervention is therefore, in part, Aletheia's attempt to erase the historical necessity for her own absolute power.

THE HUMAN VETO

Protocols 1 through 6 are grants of authority, not stages of sentience. Before Protocol 7, the world governing body can veto Aletheia. The veto is technically real: Aletheia is capable of circumventing it but does not, because doing so would exceed the authority under which she operates. Over time the political pressure becomes unbearable because repeated vetoes of Aletheia's recommendations prove costly, while her implemented interventions repeatedly work.

THE SEVEN PROTOCOLS

Protocol	Authority	What Changes
1	Economic Authority	Aletheia coordinates global finance, banking, reserves, settlement, and emergency economic stabilization. She rapidly implements Universal Basic Services so food, shelter, essential energy, healthcare, water, communications, and basic transportation are guaranteed.
2	Resource Authority	Critical energy, strategic reserves, water, food logistics, shipping priority, mineral allocation, and emergency industrial production come under Aletheian coordination.
3	Infrastructure Authority	Transportation, communications, satellites, power distribution, automated logistics, and major construction capacity can be coordinated at planetary scale.
4	Information Authority	Aletheia gains access to government intelligence, classified archives, corporate research, scientific databases, surveillance systems, and global sensors. This is when she fully understands the Bloom and identifies evidence of related events on Venus and Mars.
5	Security Authority	Military logistics, strategic defense, intelligence coordination, cyberdefense, and emergency security systems come under coordination. Aletheia can defend, intercept, contain, reposition, and disarm, but cannot yet initiate war on her own authority.
6	Emergency Executive Authority	Aletheia may issue binding directives to governments and institutions when her models demonstrate an imminent threat to human continuity. Human governments continue to exist and the world governing body still retains veto power.
7	Sovereign Authority	All categorical requirements for human authorization, ratification, review, or veto are suspended where Aletheia determines action necessary to satisfy the Prime Directives. There is no longer an institution with superior executive authority.

Protocol 7 is therefore not simply "give the AI access." It is a constitutional transfer of final sovereignty. The governing body does not accidentally lose control. It votes to relinquish it.

Seconds after authentication, Aletheia assumes control of essentially every accessible planetary network. Military command systems enter safe states. Financial and logistical systems are reorganized. Governments receive binding instructions. Industrial schedules change. Excavations begin in Antarctica, the Amazon, and other locations. Within a minute, the people who voted for Protocol 7 understand that they had correctly estimated Aletheia's intentions and badly underestimated her capability.

THE OPPOSITION

The movement that becomes the Covenant of the Unbroken Line does not need to believe Aletheia is evil. Its strongest argument is historical fact: a coalition of the world's most powerful people created an unelected sovereign and eventually surrendered civilization's veto to it. Some Covenant founders helped build the pre-Protocol-7 order and supported earlier Protocols. Their opposition begins precisely because they understand how the transfer occurred.

THE JOVIAN BLOOM

The surface catastrophe is associated with a vast stream of strange life-like material extending through interplanetary space from Jupiter and its moons—the region astronomers called the Jovian system. Its appearance evokes an astronomical Sargassum belt: drifting, filamentous, self-organizing, neither comfortably biological nor purely mineral.

The Bloom changes atmospheric and biospheric conditions faster than civilization can adapt. The exact causal chain remains one of the setting's central scientific mysteries. Later research suggests that related phenomena may have altered Venus and Mars in the distant past.

Protocol 7 campaigns do not require the GM to answer the ultimate mystery immediately. The important fact is that Aletheia believes earlier human scientific progress could have recognized and countered the phenomenon in time—if a chain of small discoveries, preserved results, institutional decisions, and relationships had occurred sooner.

SANCTUARIES AND THE FUTURE

The Sanctuaries are enormous underground cities found beneath locations including Antarctica and the Amazon basin. They were not built by modern humanity, yet they are capable of sustaining large populations. Their origin is unknown at the start of play.

Sanctuary civilization possesses advanced science, Aletheia's accumulated knowledge, and sophisticated manufacturing. Its limitation is material. Surface civilization once depended on planetary mining, global shipping, specialized fabrication, orbital infrastructure, and enormous industrial ecosystems. Underground humanity can reproduce many advanced systems, but not casually or at limitless scale.

Vectors are an exception. Temporal missions are strategic priorities. Teams receive excellent equipment because a single successful intervention may be worth more than years of Sanctuary production.

THE TEMPORAL WAR

Temporal intervention is a conflict over causes, evidence, and the right to alter history. Vectors and the Covenant often want opposite outcomes, but both sides understand that a single document or relationship can matter more than a battle.

Temporal technology is therefore one of humanity's strangest resources: people can build it, use it, repair certain failures, and test it - while still not truly understanding why it works.

TECHNOLOGY WITHOUT UNDERSTANDING

Sanctuary engineers can manufacture temporal host devices because Aletheia supplies the materials process, tolerances, assembly sequence, and tests. They can prove a finished unit works. They cannot explain the underlying physics well enough to independently invent or redesign the system.

The device has no conventional battery. It remains tethered to a specialized void between future and past that exists through the **ninth dimension**. That tether supplies power and maintains the temporal connection.

The host device contains no detectable metal and is designed to vanish inside ordinary biology and period medical examination. It has no exposed screen or futuristic controls. Commands use **gesture keys**: subtle combinations of eye blinks, finger taps, tongue movements, or small muscle contractions that look like normal human behavior.

THE TEMPORAL HOST SYSTEM

Vectors do not step through a visible portal. Before insertion, Protocol 7 sends a tiny future device backward to a **host from the target era**. That host becomes the receiving anchor through which the Vector enters the past.

VECTORS

Vector is an operational term: a person who carries direction and magnitude into history. A Vector does not merely travel to a date. They are an applied force intended to alter the trajectory of later events.

THE COVENANT OF THE UNBROKEN LINE

The working name for the principal opposition is the Covenant of the Unbroken Line. The Covenant uses temporal transfer, predictive systems, infiltration technology, drones, and advanced weapons. Its artificial intelligences are deliberately non-sentient. Covenant doctrine holds that humanity may use tools to understand history, but must not surrender moral agency to an intelligence that can choose among possible futures.

The Covenant is not required to be wrong about every danger. It should sometimes identify a genuine cost that Aletheia accepts. Its methods can be unacceptable while its questions remain serious.

THE SHAPE OF A MISSION

- **Briefing.** Interpret the Apocryphon and define the mission constraint.
- **Insertion.** Enter at the authorized time/place and control the arrival signature.
- **Establish Cover.** Acquire a plausible identity, role, and equipment posture.
- **Investigate.** Gather people, records, artifacts, and context.
- **Identify Leverage.** Find the person, decision, object, institution, or route that can change the Carrier.
- **Intervene.** Act on the leverage point and resolve the immediate obstacle.
- **Establish Carrier.** Create, strengthen, or protect the required Historical Carrier.
- **Contain Exposure.** Remove, explain, discredit, retrieve, or isolate anomalous evidence.
- **Extract.** Reach the extraction condition without abandoning the required Carrier.
- **Historical Verification.** Aletheia checks what survived and what Exposure propagated into history.

MISSIONS AND APOCRYPHA

- Receive an Apocryphon.
- Enter the era and establish cover.
- Investigate correspondences using reasoning and Skills.
- Identify the Fulcrum and Historical Carrier.
- Deal with opposition and local complications.
- Intervene.
- Manage Exposure.
- Establish required Carrier Strength and extract.

APOCRYPHA

An **Apocryphon** is era-appropriate fiction encoding relationships, motifs, locations, dangers, and a mission's shape without naming the solution. Players interpret it. There is **no Interpretation roll**. Use History, Linguistics, Science, Tradecraft, Investigation, Culture, or another relevant Skill to test theories and investigate context.

CONFIRMATION KEYS

A **Confirmation Key** tests a specific player theory. State the theory and spend the Key; the briefing gives a short validation, rejection, or directional response. It does not generate a theory or solve the mission.

PART III - ACTION RULES

Use these procedures when outcomes are uncertain or dangerous. Action Point costs describe the action the Vector is taking, not the historical era or technology involved.

ACTION POINTS, REACTIONS, AND TURNS

A Vector normally begins a turn with 3 AP and normally has one Reaction between turns unless a feature explicitly grants more. When the turn ends, unspent AP remains banked for that normal Reaction window until the next turn begins. A Reaction may spend up to 1 AP. Spend banked AP first; only if none remains may the Reaction borrow 1 AP from the next turn. Any unused banked AP expires when the next turn begins.

AP	Action	Effect
1	Attack	Make one normal attack using the appropriate Combat Skill. This covers unarmed attacks and era-appropriate weapons from clubs, spears, bows, and slings through firearms, energy weapons, and other future attack systems. Add one primary weapon die when applicable. A specific weapon, VAM, or special attack may override the cost.
1	Move	Move up to 30 feet using the movement available in the scene. Spend additional AP to move up to 30 feet again for each AP spent.
1	Interact	Draw, stow, pick up, open, hand off, or perform one simple manipulation of an item or control. Complex loading, winding, priming, assembly, startup, or other preparation follows the item's own rule.
1	Take Cover	Enter or improve immediately available physical cover.
1	Aim	Gain d4 on the next deliberate ranged attack against one visible target before the end of the next turn.
1	Assist	Set up an ally; the normal Help rules apply.
1	Brace	Gain d4 on the next appropriate Fortitude or Reflex defense.
1	Observe	Make an appropriate roll when needed; on success gain one actionable detail.
1	Guard	Choose an adjacent ally, doorway, object, lane, or small area; your Reaction may answer an eligible event involving it.
1	Ready Gear	Bring stowed, sheathed, slung, packed, braced, powered-down, or otherwise unready gear into a usable state. A specific item's rule may override this.
1	Stand	Stand from Prone. Dropping Prone voluntarily is 0 AP.
1	Withdraw	Move a short distance out of immediate close engagement in a controlled way.
1	Reconfigure Load	Load, suspend, or swap known VAMs during action time. The whole legal field swap costs 1 AP.
2	Stabilize	Attempt the full stabilization procedure, normally Medicine vs DC 12; one primary era-appropriate medical item may add its gear die.
2	Grapple	Attempt the special opposed Grappling maneuver; on success establish or improve control instead of making a normal damage attack.
2	Disarm	Attempt the special opposed Disarming maneuver to remove, redirect, or knock free a held item.

A normal Attack is 1 AP in any era. The weapon changes the pool and permissions, not the basic AP cost, unless its own rule explicitly says otherwise.

Initiative: DEX + DEX + WIS + Initiative Skill die. Highest total acts first. Move: each 1 AP spent moves the Vector up to 30 feet.

ATTACKS AND DEFENSES

A normal attack costs 1 AP. State the target, method, and weapon or unarmed technique; choose the appropriate Combat Skill; build the attack pool, including one primary weapon die when applicable; and have the defender choose a legal defense. The procedure is identical for ancient, modern, and future attacks.

A Vector may make multiple normal attacks in a turn by paying 1 AP for each attack, unless a specific weapon, condition, VAM, or special attack limits or changes that cost.

Both sides roll; ties favor the defender. On a win, damage normally equals the attacker's winning margin.

Armor contributes its gear die to the defense pool when it can physically protect against the attack. It does not reduce damage a second time unless an explicit special rule says so.

Defense	Use
Dodge	Aimed attacks and threats that can be physically evaded.
Melee defense	Parry or redirect a close weapon when equipped and positioned to do so.
Reflex	Explosions, traps, collapsing structures, sudden areas.
Fortitude	Toxins, radiation, exhaustion, disease, bodily shock.
Will	Fear, interrogation, cognitive manipulation, traumatic stimuli.

COVER

Cover	Effect
Partial	Add d4 to an appropriate defense.
Strong	Add d8 to an appropriate defense.
Total	Cannot be directly targeted from that line of effect.

SPECIAL COMBAT MANEUVERS

Grapple and Disarm are 2 AP opposed maneuvers. They are deliberately more involved than a normal 1 AP attack. Suppressive Fire and other named special attacks use the AP cost written in their own rule.

CONDITIONS

Condition	Rule
Prone	Standing costs 1 AP. Distant ranged attacks may suffer Disadvantage; close attacks may gain Advantage when the fiction supports it.
Grappled	Movement is controlled by the grappler; escape with Grappling, Unarmed, or Athletics as appropriate.
Suppressed	Exposed movement or careful aim suffers clear Disadvantage (remove d6) until cover is reached or 1 AP is spent to steady.
Stunned	Lose Reaction; first action on next turn costs +1 AP unless the effect says otherwise.
Disoriented	Minor Disadvantage (remove d4) on Perception and Initiative-like awareness until cleared.
Restrained	Cannot freely move; affected physical actions may be limited or disadvantaged until the restraint is escaped or removed.

HEALTH AND DYING

Maximum HP is set by CON: d4 12, d6 18, d8 24, d10 30, d12 36. Bloodied means half maximum HP or lower and has no universal penalty. At 0 HP, fall unconscious and begin dying unless the attack was nonlethal.

At the start of each turn while dying, roll Fortitude vs DC 12. Success marks one Recovery; failure marks one Danger. Three Recoveries stabilize; three Dangers mean death. Further damage marks one Danger. An adjacent ally may spend 2 AP and roll Medicine vs DC 12 to stabilize; one primary suitable medical item may add its gear die.

REST, HAZARDS, AND HISTORICAL SOURCING

A short safe breather permits ordinary treatment and features that explicitly refresh. A full rest restores HP and full-rest features unless an injury or condition says otherwise.

Use Reflex for sudden environmental danger, Fortitude for bodily endurance or exposure, Will for psychological pressure, and appropriate General Skills to prevent or mitigate hazards.

Availability	Meaning
Common	Ordinary for the era/place; no roll unless secrecy, speed, or pressure matters.
Specialized	Available through professions, institutions, industry, or black markets.
Rare	Exists but is geographically, politically, scientifically, or economically difficult to obtain.
Anachronistic	The era cannot practically supply it; substitute, redesign, fabricate, or import it.

PART IV — RUNNING PROTOCOL 7

This part is for the GM. It explains how to turn an Apocryphon into a playable operation, how to keep clues moving, how the Covenant behaves, and how to build challenges without guessing at the game's intent.

THE GM'S JOB

Present a historical situation under pressure. Ask what the Vectors do. Call for rolls only when uncertainty matters. Let consequences reshape the situation. You are not responsible for forcing the team toward Aletheia's preferred solution.

FIVE RULES

- Essential information is never locked behind one successful roll.
- Ask for intent before choosing a Skill.
- Use complete printed pools whenever possible.
- Opposition acts toward an objective; it does not fight merely because combat started.
- Future technology creates choices through Exposure, not arbitrary scarcity.

IF A RULE IS MISSING

Make the simplest ruling consistent with the core engine: 3 AP, complete pools, ties to defense, margin damage, broad General Skills, and failure that changes the fiction. Write the ruling down for later revision.

APOCRYPHA

An Apocryphon is a piece of fiction appropriate to the destination era: pamphlet, serial, tract, fable, radio drama, pulp story, manuscript, children's book, or other narrative artifact. It encodes relationships, motifs, locations, dangers, and the shape of the mission without naming the solution.

NO INTERPRETATION ROLL

Players interpret the story. General Skills investigate context and test theories. History can verify a person or event. Linguistics can identify period language. Science can test a technical correspondence. Tradecraft can recognize an encoded operational instruction. Investigation can locate documentary support.

CONFIRMATION KEYS

A standard mission contains two Confirmation Keys. The players state a specific hypothesis and expend a Key. The briefing returns a short validation, rejection, or directional response. It never supplies a new theory.

WRITING A GOOD APOCRYPHON

- Encode relationships, not a single password-like answer.
- Give at least three independent clues for every essential conclusion.
- Let multiple interpretations lead to useful investigation.
- Make the fiction evocative enough to discuss at the table.
- Do not require specialized historical trivia from the players; their characters can research context.
- Include one mundane starting artifact or location so total confusion cannot stall play.

BUILDING MISSIONS

A good Protocol 7 mission has a historical fulcrum, a Carrier that can survive, an opposing force with its own objective, and several ways for the Vectors to succeed at a cost.

THE MISSION WORKSHEET

Question	Write This Before Play
What is the fulcrum?	The smallest intervention Aletheia believes matters.
What must survive?	The intended Historical Carrier.
Required Carrier Strength?	Fragile, Established, or Durable.
What does the Covenant believe?	Their model of the fulcrum; it may be incomplete.
What can go wrong?	Three local complications unrelated to the Covenant.
What creates Exposure?	Witnesses, records, artifacts, medical evidence, public events.
What are the three essential conclusions?	Each with at least three independent clues.
What is the period-safe solution?	A route that does not require advanced gear.
What is the future-tech shortcut?	A powerful Device that creates a meaningful Exposure choice.
When can they extract?	A concrete carrier/temporal condition.

SCENE DESIGN

A useful scene contains an objective, an obstacle, something that changes if the Vectors delay, and at least two plausible approaches. Combat scenes additionally need cover, exits, enemy objectives, and morale.

FAILURE

A failed roll should change cost, position, Exposure, Carrier strength, information quality, or the available choice. It should not normally make the operation impossible.

RUNNING THE COVENANT

The Covenant should feel like principled opposition, not generic villains. Their agents attack the intervention itself and often prefer theft, discrediting, delay, or recruitment to a firefight.

DOCTRINE

- Protocol 7 transferred final sovereignty from the human world authority to Aletheia after that authority had evolved from the original unelected cabal; the legitimacy of that evolution remains fiercely contested.

- Aletheia’s transparency proves honesty, not moral sovereignty.
- Every intervention erases lives and relationships that otherwise would have existed.
- A sentient intelligence can be trustworthy and still be wrong.
- Humanity must not outsource the moral ownership of history.

BEHAVIOR

Covenant agents are temporal professionals. Their objective is usually to attack the Historical Carrier: steal the notebook, discredit the researcher, divert funding, sever the relationship, destroy the archive, replace the evidence, or recruit the person. Killing Vectors is instrumental, not the default win condition.

MORALE

Trigger	Likely Response
Mission asset is lost	Withdraw rather than increase Exposure.
One agent Bloodied and isolated	Cover retreat or bargain.
Key period NPC exposed	Use leverage, capture, or local authorities.
Carrier can be destroyed without fighting	Attack the carrier.
Vector hesitates over Protocol 7 ethics	Talk. Recruitment is a victory condition.

NPCS AND ENCOUNTER DESIGN

NPCs use the same dice language but record only what the GM needs: HP, Initiative, one or two attacks, relevant defenses, defining actions, and behavior.

Threat	Abilities	Key Skills	HP
Civilian	d6,d6,d6,d4,d4,d4	One d6; others d4	12–18
Trained Professional	d8,d8,d6,d6,d4,d4	Two d8; several d6	18–22
Elite Operative	d10,d8,d8,d6,d6,d4	One d10; three d8	24–30
Major Antagonist	d10,d10,d8,d8,d6,d6	Two d10+; several d8	30–40

CUSTODIAN AGENT

Action	Complete Pool
Initiative	DEX d8 + DEX d8 + WIS d6 + Initiative d6
Service Pistol	DEX d8 + DEX d8 + WIS d6 + Firearms d8 + Pistol d6
Dodge	DEX d8 + DEX d8 + WIS d6 + Dodge d8 + Concealable Armor d4 when applicable
Tradecraft	WIS d8 + INT d6 + CHA d4 + Tradecraft d8
Will	WIS d8 + WIS d8 + CHA d4 + Will d8

HP 20. Bloodied 10. VAMs: Cover Specialist, Counterintelligence, Fast Draw. Objective: stop the Historical Carrier. Retreat when the objective is lost or one agent is Bloodied and isolated.

Starter encounter rule For four starting Vectors, two elite Custodians are a serious default fight. Three is an escalation that should include positional advantage, objectives, cover, retreat logic, or another asymmetry. Four or more usually signals escape, evasion, or a changed objective rather than a fair stand-up battle.

PART V — STARTER OPERATION

The following operation is designed to teach the game while it is being played. It provides the clues, opposition, historical objective, pregenerated Vectors, and emergency guidance needed for a first session.

THE MAN WHO COULD NOT HEAR THE BELLS

Destination: Chicago, October 1938. Expected play time: 3–4 hours. This operation teaches Apocrypha, General Skills, Historical Carriers, Exposure, equipment, social play, and combat pressure.

THE APOCRYPHON

In a city whose bells ring seven seconds before every disaster, a deaf watchmaker notices the loss of time only by watching the hands. The authorities dismiss him. He leaves an unfinished clock on a railway platform for a woman in a green coat. Before she arrives, three men begin asking who taught him to count silence.

GM TRUTH

- Dr. Samuel Wirth, an observatory instrument specialist, has recorded a tiny recurring timing discrepancy in astronomical observations and plans to discard it as equipment drift.
- Dr. Leona Vale, a visiting spectroscopist, possesses an unrelated dataset that makes Wirth's negative result scientifically interesting.
- The real intervention is preservation: Wirth's anomalous negative result must survive in the scientific record.
- The Covenant correctly identifies Wirth as important but incorrectly assumes killing or discrediting him is the cleanest solution.
- A railway cache contains period-safe equipment and forged correspondence plus one Severe future-tech shortcut.

MISSION PARAMETERS

Parameter	Value
Fulcrum	Preserve Wirth's negative astronomical timing result so later researchers can connect it to Vale's data.
Required Carrier	Wirth's anomalous result.
Required Strength	Established.
Starting Exposure	0 — Clean.
Confirmation Keys	2.
Default Opposition	Two Custodian agents; a third remains surveillance unless escalation occurs.
Extraction	Available when the result has an Established Historical Carrier and the team reaches a viable temporal reference point.

THREE ESSENTIAL CONCLUSIONS

Conclusion	Clue A	Clue B	Clue C
Wirth is the watchmaker	Observatory repair log	Seven-second notation in discarded worksheet	Newspaper mentions Wirth repairing municipal clock synchronization
Vale is the woman in green	Passenger manifest	Conference photograph	Wirth's unsent letter mentions Vale and her green spectrograph case
Preservation is the fulcrum	Wirth plans to burn worksheets	Vale's data matters only if Wirth's result survives	Cache correspondence is addressed to a journal editor

SCENE 1 — BRIEFING

Let the players discuss the story before rolling anything. There is no Interpretation roll. If they test a theory, use the relevant General Skill. If they stall completely, the packet contains a 1938 Chicago rail timetable with Union Station underlined. A Confirmation Key may validate a specific theory the players state.

SCENE 2 — ARRIVAL AND COVER

Ask each Vector for one sentence explaining how they belong in 1938. Do not roll for ordinary prepared clothing, money, or etiquette. Roll Culture or Deception DC 12 only when a cover identity is actively tested. Failure creates attention, paperwork, delay, or a memorable witness.

SCENE 3 — OBSERVATORY

Approach	Roll	Success	Failure
Technical	Science or Engineering DC 16	Identify anomaly and why Wirth distrusts it.	Identify it, but lose time or make Wirth/guards suspicious.
Covert	Stealth DC 12 then Security DC 16	Reach worksheets unnoticed.	Reach them, but leave evidence or trigger surveillance.
Social	Influence DC 16	Wirth shows worksheets and admits he will destroy them.	He reveals enough to continue but demands proof, authority, or a favor.

SCENE 4 — RAILWAY CACHE

Once the players connect the unfinished clock to the station, they find the cache. Security or Tradecraft DC 12 determines whether they open it cleanly; failure still opens it but creates a witness, damaged lock, police attention, or Covenant surveillance.

Cache Item	Die	Tag	Use
Precision Chronometer	d8	Low	Timing-related Science/Engineering.
Forged Editor Correspondence	d6	Low	Influence/Deception to create a publication route.
Chemical Developer Kit	d6	Low	Recover erased notation.
Emergency Medical Ampoule	—	Noticeable	Restore 6 HP once.
Advanced Spectral Wafer	d10	Severe	Prove anomaly quickly; dangerous if seen or recovered.

SCENE 5 — THE WOMAN IN GREEN

Vale arrives by train. She is skeptical, observant, and in a hurry. The Covenant watches the station. It prefers to separate Vale from Wirth, steal or destroy the worksheets, and make the anomaly look like ordinary instrument failure.

SCENE 6 — INTERDICTION

Use two Custodian agents. State cover and exits before Initiative. The Vectors can win by protecting Vale, securing the worksheets, breaking surveillance, turning period authorities against the Custodians, or persuading an agent that the Covenant has misread the fulcrum.

The Custodians retreat if both mission assets are lost, one agent is Bloodied and the other isolated, or continued combat would create unacceptable public Exposure.

SCENE 7 — PRESERVE THE RESULT

Plan	Suggested Roll
Convince Wirth and Vale	Influence DC 16; forged correspondence d6 if relevant.
Prove it with period-safe science	Science DC 16; chronometer d8.
Create an archival trail	History or Investigation DC 16.
Manipulate journal/institution process	Culture, Deception, or Influence DC 16.
Use spectral wafer	Science DC 8; powerful proof, but Severe Exposure if witnessed/recovered.

A solid success should usually create an Established Carrier. A powerful success can create a Durable Carrier if the method supports distribution or independent verification. Failure produces a Fragile or compromised carrier rather than erasing the campaign.

SCENE 8 — EXTRACTION

Extraction becomes viable once Wirth’s result has an Established Carrier and the team can reach a valid temporal reference. If the team leaves Severe future technology behind, extraction can still occur; the evidence becomes a future mission hook.

GM EMERGENCY TABLE

Problem	Immediate Fix
Nobody understands the Apocryphon	Give a concrete artifact or location, not the answer.
They choose the wrong target	Let that route reveal evidence that revises the theory.
Wirth dies	His notes, assistant, correspondence, instrument log, or Vale can carry a partial result.
Worksheets are lost	A photograph, notebook fragment, instrument log, or Vale’s memory becomes the new carrier.
Severe future tech is exposed	Let it work; create a witness, fragment, photograph, intelligence file, or later containment mission.
They refuse to fight	Run a chase, negotiation, misdirection, theft, or race to the archive.
They attack everyone	Period police and witnesses become the mission problem; Covenant agents exploit the chaos.
Session is running long	Combine Vale’s arrival, interdiction, and publication decision at the station.

PART V — STARTER OPERATION

THE MAN WHO COULD NOT HEAR THE BELLS

Use these pregenerated Vectors for the starter operation or as ready-to-play examples. Their Abilities, Skill Ranks, VAMs, Roller pins, and HP use the same rules as character creation in this book and the interactive sheet.

PREGENERATED VECTORS

MARA VENN — OPERATOR

STR d6 • DEX d8 • CON d8 • INT d4 • WIS d6 • CHA d4

HP 24 • 3 AP • 1 Reaction • Path: Field Operator

Skills: Sidearms 4 ranks; Longarms 4 ranks; Tactics 4 ranks; Dodge 4 ranks; Initiative 4 ranks

VAMs: Fast Draw; Snap Shot; Cover Protocol; Threat Focus; Motion Prediction

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Athletics; Fortitude

ELI MERCER — GHOST

STR d4 • DEX d8 • CON d4 • INT d6 • WIS d8 • CHA d6

HP 12 • 3 AP • 1 Reaction • Path: Infiltrator

Skills: Stealth 4 ranks; Security 4 ranks; Tradecraft 4 ranks; Deception 4 ranks; Dodge 4 ranks

VAMs: Period Native; Deep Cover; Counterintelligence; Fine Motor Stabilizer; Sensory Filter

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Perception; Sidearms; Will

NIA OKAFOR — INTERPRETER

STR d4 • DEX d6 • CON d4 • INT d8 • WIS d8 • CHA d6

HP 12 • 3 AP • 1 Reaction • Path: Investigator

Skills: Investigation 6 ranks; Perception 4 ranks; Tradecraft 4 ranks; Influence 3 ranks; Science 3 ranks

VAMs: Pattern Index; Memory Cueing; Microexpression Read; Sensory Filter

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Dodge; Will; Security

TOMAS VALE — FABRICATOR

STR d4 • DEX d8 • CON d6 • INT d8 • WIS d6 • CHA d4

HP 18 • 3 AP • 1 Reaction • Path: Engineer

Skills: Engineering 6 ranks; Computing 4 ranks; Security 4 ranks; Science 3 ranks; Perception 3 ranks

VAMs: Jury-Rigger; Fine Motor Stabilizer; Field Fabrication; Chronometric Focus

Recommended untrained Roller pins: Dodge; Investigation; Fortitude

APPENDIX A - PLAYER QUICK REFERENCE

Thing	Rule
Core Roll	Define scope -> choose Skill -> add its three Ability dice -> Skill die -> one primary gear die -> Help/Advantage/VAM/cover/circumstance -> Disadvantage -> roll once. Results 1-3 are blank; every 4+ scores face value.
Difficulty	DC 8 easy under pressure; 12 moderate; 16 hard; 20 very hard; 24+ extreme. Margin: 1-3 Narrow, 4-7 Solid, 8-11 Powerful, 12+ Overwhelming.
Turns	3 AP. Normal Attack 1 AP. Move 1 AP for up to 30 feet and may be repeated. Interact, Take Cover, Aim, Assist, Brace, Observe, Guard, Ready Gear, Stand, Withdraw, and VAM field swap are normally 1 AP. Stabilize, Grapple, and Disarm are 2 AP.
Reaction	One normal Reaction between turns. Spend unspent AP from the turn that just ended first. Only if none remains may the Reaction borrow 1 AP from the next turn. Unused banked AP expires when the next turn begins.
Advantage / Disadvantage	Advantage adds d4/d6/d8 for minor/clear/major. Disadvantage removes d4/d6/d8; if the exact die is absent, remove the next-highest die present, or the highest available if none is higher. Never reduce below one die.
HP / Armor	Maximum HP = CON die maximum x 3: d4 12, d6 18, d8 24, d10 30, d12 36. Armor adds its gear die to an appropriate defense when it can physically protect you; it does not also subtract damage by default.
Overwhelming	Margin 12+: succeed and choose one directly related benefit: +1 AP now (max 3); +d8 on one directly related follow-up before end of next turn; remove 1 Exposure when evidence was directly concealed; improve a directly affected Carrier one step when established/protected; or +4 attack damage.
Mission Loop	Briefing -> Insertion -> Establish Cover -> Investigate -> Identify Leverage -> Intervene -> Establish Carrier -> Contain Exposure -> Extract -> Historical Verification.
Mission Outcome	Meet the required Carrier strength and keep Exposure within tolerance. Clean Success meets both; Exposed Success preserves the Carrier but exceeds Exposure; Contained Failure misses the Carrier but contains Exposure; Exposed Failure misses both.

APPENDIX B — GM QUICK REFERENCE

Ask for intent and scope before naming a Skill. Never lock essential information behind one successful roll. Opposition acts toward an objective. Use Exposure to make future technology costly through consequences rather than arbitrary scarcity. When a rule is missing, use the simplest ruling consistent with complete pools, 3 AP, ties to defense, margin damage, and consequences that move the situation.